INCOMPLETE. Added in the gap-fill pass (search extracts only): KPMG/Melbourne 2025 hidden-use figures; Gallup's primary manager-support figures (80% vs 44% frequent use); BCG sample details; three field experiments (Copilot across 66 firms, Gap/Microsoft training RCT, Kenya RCT); measured scale of middle-management cuts. Still missing: any causal study of de-layering's effect on adoption or productivity (none appears to exist); an independent, peer-reviewed RCT of AI training on business outcomes; Gartner's manager research; the primary source of Gallup's "8.7-fold" figure. Most non-Microsoft/Anthropic figures are from search extracts and need primary re-check.

Track 4: Inertia and education

Last updated: 2026-11-06. Labels: EVIDENCE = measured/primary data; FORECAST = projection; OPINION = argument, vendor or consultancy view.

Verification note (added 2026-11-06): page fetches were blocked for most hosts this session, so findings marked search summary, search extract or snippet rest on search-engine extracts of the cited URL. Quotation marks inside findings mark wording as reported by that source; only quotes in this file's "Verbatim quotes" section (and in 13-quotes.md) were checked against a fetched page. Corrections from the verification pass are in verification.md.

> **Access caveat (read first).** This session's network blocked almost every primary host: bcg.com, gallup.com, mckinsey.com, pewresearch.org, stlouisfed.org, nber.org, iza.org, pnas.org, ssrn.com, arxiv.org, tandfonline.com, upwork.com, gartner.com and others. Only microsoft.com and anthropic.com could be fetched. The shared web-search budget also ran out partway through. So I could check figures against the raw page only for Microsoft's Work Trend Index (2024, 2025) and Anthropic's own studies. Every other figure here comes from search-engine summaries of the primary or secondary pages. Those are marked **[search-summary]** and need re-checking against the primary before publication. Where I know the primary URL, I give it.
>
> Not covered, because the search budget ran out before I reached them: Gartner on managers; the KPMG/University of Melbourne 2025 trust study (hidden AI use, 47 countries); randomised field experiments on AI training; academic studies of de-layering. See Open questions.

Summary

- **The "70% of change programmes fail" figure has no empirical basis.** Hughes (2011, Journal of Change Management) traced five widely cited sources (Hammer & Champy, Beer & Nohria, Bain, McKinsey, Kotter) and found no valid, reliable evidence behind them. The Hammer & Champy origin was openly described as an "unscientific estimate". A same-volume paper by Burnes & Jackson asserts the opposite, so the figure is contested rather than settled. Either way, it should not prop up the thesis.
- **Workers are not, on the whole, resisting the tool. They are adopting it faster than their employers.** Microsoft/LinkedIn (2024, n=31,000, verified): 78% of AI users bring their own AI tools to work, and 52% are reluctant to admit using it for their most important tasks. In Denmark (Humlum & Vestergaard), the barriers workers cite most are employer restrictions and a need for training, not unwillingness [search-summary]. The friction sits more with organisational permission, policy and training than with individual resistance.

- **Resistance, where it exists, looks rational.** In the 2024 Work Trend Index, 53% of AI users worry that using it on important tasks makes them look replaceable (verified). Pew (Oct 2024, n=5,273 US workers): 52% are worried and 36% hopeful [search-summary]. Upwork's much-quoted "77% say AI added to my workload" comes from a vendor survey in which the 77% applies only to the roughly 1,250 non-executive respondents (625 employees, 625 freelancers) in four countries [search-summary].
- **Manager support matters, and is weak.** In BCG's 2025 survey, frontline regular use stalled at 51%, only about a quarter of frontline staff felt they had enough leadership support, and positive sentiment rose from 15% to 55% with strong leadership support (all [search-summary], cross-sectional). Gallup names manager support as a top driver of frequent use while manager engagement fell from 27% to 22% in 2025 [search-summary]. Gallup's own figures: 80% frequent use where managers actively support AI vs 44% where support is low (private sector), with only 28-36% of employees reporting strong support (gap-fill pass, search extract). The randomised Copilot rollout across 66 firms found weekly use ranging from 21% to 75% by firm, so the organisation clearly matters, even if nobody has isolated which part of it. Big tech is cutting manager layers at the same time, and I found no rigorous evidence on what that does to adoption.
- **"Teach a new way of working, not a tool" has only correlational support.** McKinsey's "workflow redesign is the attribute most linked to EBIT impact" is a self-reported, cross-sectional association from a consultancy that sells redesign (OPINION). The theory behind it is stronger: Brynjolfsson, Rock & Syverson (2021) on intangible complementary investment and the productivity J-curve.
- **Adoption gaps by gender survive equal access, so training and access alone do not close them.** A meta-analysis by Otis, Cranney, Delecourt & Koning finds women about 20% less likely than men to use generative AI, and the gap persists where access is equalised [search-summary]. Younger workers use AI more and in Pew are more hopeful, not more anxious [search-summary].
- **The biggest challenge to the thesis is about magnitude, not readiness.** In Denmark, wide adoption with employer encouragement produced average time savings of about 3% and no detectable effect on earnings or hours (Humlum & Vestergaard, NBER w33777) [search-summary]. If adoption is fast but gains are small, the binding constraint may be how much value the tool adds to typical tasks, not "business readiness".

Key findings

1. Change-management evidence: the 70% myth and what is actually known

- **[EVIDENCE]** Hughes, "Do 70 Per Cent of All Organizational Change Initiatives Really Fail?", Journal of Change Management 11(4): 451–464 (2011). He reviews five published sources of the 70% figure (Hammer & Champy; Beer & Nohria; a Bain article; a McKinsey article; Kotter). He traces their supporting references back to a 2002 article by Pace and Mulvin, which itself cites Beer & Nohria's HBR piece. He concludes there is no valid and reliable empirical evidence for the narrative. [search-summary] https://research.brighton.ac.uk/en/publications/do-70-per-cent-of-all-organizational-change-initiatives-really-fa/
- **[EVIDENCE]** Hughes published a reflection in the same journal in 2022. He says he searched for evidence for the claim without success. [search-summary] https://informahealthcare.com/doi/abs/10.1080/14697017.2022.2030980 (DOI 10.1080/14697017.2022.2030980)
- **[OPINION]** Hammer & Champy (Reengineering the Corporation, 1993) give the original reengineering figure as their own "unscientific estimate" that 50% to 70% of reengineering

efforts fall short of the dramatic results intended. I saw this only as a quote in secondary summaries and have paraphrased it. [search-summary] https://strategyu.co/do-70-percent-of-change-initiatives-really-fail

- **[OPINION]** Counterpoint: Burnes & Jackson (2011, same journal volume) state that substantial evidence shows about 70% of change initiatives fail. I could not check their evidence base. [search-summary] https://research.brighton.ac.uk/en/publications/do-70-per-cent-of-all-organizational-change-initiatives-really-fa/
- **Implication.** The honest framing is "change often underdelivers, and nobody has a credible base rate". Any content that says "70% of transformations fail, so AI will too" rests on a figure that started as a guess about 1990s reengineering.

2. Adoption and training: what the better data say

Population-level adoption (US)

- **[EVIDENCE]** Bick, Blandin & Deming, Real-Time Population Survey (nationally representative, US adults aged 18–64). In August 2024, 39% had used generative AI. Pooling August and November 2024, 32% of workers had used it for work. NBER w32966. [search-summary] https://ideas.repec.org/p/nbr/nberwo/32966.html
- **[EVIDENCE]** Their St Louis Fed update ("The State of Generative AI Adoption in 2025", 13 Nov 2025): adoption among adults rose about 10 points in a year to 54.6%. The share of all work hours spent using generative AI rose from 4.1% (Nov 2024) to 5.7% (Aug 2025). [search-summary] https://www.stlouisfed.org/on-the-economy/2025/nov/state-generative-ai-adoption-2025
- **[EVIDENCE]** Gallup quarterly workforce panel, Q1 2026 (fieldwork 4–19 Feb 2026, n=23,717 US employees). 50% use AI at work at least occasionally, up from 21% in Q2 2023. 28% use it frequently (a few times a week or more). [search-summary] https://www.tomshardware.com/tech-industry/artificial-intelligence/half-of-all-us-employees-now-use-artificial-intelligence-at-work-crossing-landmark-threshold-for-first-time-gallup-data-shows-daily-and-weekly-usage-hitting-all-time-high-of-28-percent-in-q1-2026-with-65-percent-feeling-positive-about-its-impact-on-productivity
- **[EVIDENCE, unverified]** Gallup Q2 2026 (May 2026), reported only in secondary coverage: about 30% frequent use and 15% daily. Employees saying their organisation has integrated AI rose from 41% to 47%. About 25% say their organisation has communicated a clear AI plan. [search-summary] https://fortune.com/2026/01/25/ai-use-frequency-employed-adults-tech-workers-retail-manufacturing-gallup-poll/ (coverage of an earlier wave; the Q2 figures need checking at news.gallup.com)
- **[EVIDENCE]** Pew (published 25 Feb 2025; survey Oct 2024; n=5,273 employed US adults). 63% don't use AI much or at all in their job. About 16% say at least some of their work is done with AI. About one in ten use chatbots daily or a few times a week. [search-summary] https://www.pewresearch.org/internet/2025/02/25/u-s-workers-are-more-worried-than-hopeful-about-future-ai-use-in-the-workplace/
- **Note on conflict.** "Half of workers use AI" (Gallup, any use) and "5.7% of work hours" (Bick et al.) are both credible. They measure breadth and depth. Breadth is high; intensity is low.

Employer encouragement and training

- **[EVIDENCE]** Humlum & Vestergaard, "The unequal adoption of ChatGPT exacerbates existing inequalities among workers", PNAS 122(1) e2414972121 (2025). Large Danish survey (11 exposed occupations) linked to administrative registers. Workers see real productivity potential but are held back by employer restrictions and a perceived need for training. In the

IZA working-paper version (DP 16992), 43% said they needed training and 35% said their employer restricted use. These percentages are from secondary reports of the working paper and are not confirmed against PNAS. [search-summary] https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:nas:journl:v:122:y:2025:p:e2414972121; https://grip.globalrelay.com/chatgpt-use-depends-on-employer-restrictions-and-training-study-finds

- **[EVIDENCE]** Humlum & Vestergaard, "Large Language Models, Small Labor Market Effects" (NBER w33777, 2025; revised Oct 2025). Danish survey of 2023–24 chatbot use linked to registers. Most employers now encourage chatbot use, and firm-led investments raise adoption and create new job tasks. Average time savings are about 3%. Effects on earnings and recorded hours are precisely estimated near zero (they rule out effects larger than about 1%, or 2% in the revision). [search-summary] https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:nbr:nberwo:33777; https://bfi.uchicago.edu/wp-content/uploads/2025/04/BFI_WP_2025-56-3.pdf
- **[EVIDENCE (weak: vendor survey, n=31,000 knowledge workers, 31 markets, online, Edelman, 15 Feb–28 Mar 2024)]** Microsoft/LinkedIn Work Trend Index 2024 (8 May 2024). 75% of knowledge workers use AI at work. Only 39% of AI users have received AI training from their company. Only 25% of companies plan to offer generative AI training that year. (Verified: curl+grep) https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index/ai-at-work-is-here-now-comes-the-hard-part
- **[EVIDENCE (weak: consultancy survey)]** BCG, AI at Work 2025 (press release 26 June 2025). Only 36% of employees say their training is enough. 18% of regular AI users report no training at all. Secondary coverage reports that BCG found five or more hours of training linked to more regular use; I could not confirm that. [search-summary] https://www.bcg.com/press/26june2025-beyond-ai-adoption-full-potential; https://www.unleash.ai/artificial-intelligence/bcgs-ai-at-work-2025-report-four-takeaways-for-hr-leaders/
- **Gap (first pass).** The first pass found no randomised field experiment that isolates the effect of training. The gap-fill pass found the three below. None is a clean, independent, peer-reviewed training RCT on real business outcomes.

Field experiments (gap-fill pass, search extracts)

- **[EVIDENCE: randomised field experiment of tool access, working paper]** Dillon, Jaffe, Immorlica and Stanton, "Shifting Work Patterns with Generative AI", NBER w33795 (2025). Microsoft 365 Copilot was randomly assigned to 7,137 knowledge workers in 66 firms, with telemetry. Weekly use among treated workers ranged from 21% to 75% depending on the firm. The authors attribute that spread to firm-level factors such as training and management practice, which they could not measure directly. Regular users cut email time substantially, but other effects were modest. Treated workers cut out-of-hours time in apps by about 0.25 hours a week (9%). The authors include Microsoft researchers. https://www.nber.org/system/files/working_papers/w33795/w33795.pdf ; arXiv https://arxiv.org/abs/2504.11436 (search extract)
    - Relevance. This is the strongest causal evidence that, once access is equal, the organisation determines usage. The size of the firm effect (21% vs 75%) supports "the transformation is the hard part". The paper cannot say which organisational factor matters.
- **[EVIDENCE: randomised field experiment of training, preprint, vendor-authored, no IRB]** "Scaffolding Human-AI Collaboration: A Field Experiment on Behavioral Protocols and Cognitive Reframing", arXiv 2604.08678 (April 2026). 388 Gap Inc. employees all had the

same AI tool. The study randomised "thought partner" mindset training against standard feature training, and also tested rigid workflows against free use.

    - The intent-to-treat analysis found no significant average difference in document quality, because 68% of participants in every group hit the maximum score (a ceiling effect).
    - The mindset-trained group did better at the top of the distribution.
    - Changes in attitude looked like recovery from earlier bad experiences, not an effect of the training.
    - All authors work at Microsoft, and the study was not submitted to an IRB.

  Gap's press release says mindset-trained staff were twice as likely to produce top-quality work (paraphrased), and that teams forced into rigid AI workflows scored about 5 points lower. The first is a top-tail result, not an average effect. https://arxiv.org/abs/2604.08678 ; Gap release https://www.gapinc.com/en-ca/articles/2026/04/gap-inc-and-microsoft-research-explores-how-human- (search extracts)

- **[EVIDENCE: randomised field experiment of access to an AI advisor, peer-reviewed]** Otis, Clarke, Delecourt, Holtz and Koning, Management Science (2025). 640 Kenyan entrepreneurs were given a GPT-4 mentor on WhatsApp. There was no detectable average effect. High baseline performers gained about 15%, and low performers lost about 8%. The difference came from which advice they chose to act on. https://pubsonline.informs.org/doi/10.1287/mnsc.2024.06909 (search extract). See 03-smb.md.

- **[EVIDENCE, weak: lab experiment]** A 2026 arXiv lab study (Anand, arXiv 2605.18143) with participants standing in for early-career knowledge workers reports that brief training reduced the variance of performance without lowering its mean. I saw only a truncated extract. https://arxiv.org/html/2605.18143 (search extract)

- **Synthesis.** The randomised evidence says: (1) with access held equal, firms differ hugely in uptake; (2) a training intervention's effect on average output is hard to detect, and any gains show up in the tails; (3) gains go to people who already have good judgement. None of this shows that training reliably works. All of it shows that tool access alone does not determine outcomes.

3. Teaching a new way of working, not a new tool

- **[OPINION / weak EVIDENCE: consultancy survey, self-reported, cross-sectional]** McKinsey, "The state of AI: How organizations are rewiring to capture value" (March 2025). Of 25 organisational attributes tested, workflow redesign had the biggest association with self-reported EBIT impact from generative AI. Only 21% of respondents using generative AI had fundamentally redesigned at least some workflows. [search-summary; from a secondary briefing, not McKinsey's text] https://artificialintellitools.blogspot.com/2025/04/briefing-document-state-of-ai-how.html
- **[OPINION / weak EVIDENCE]** McKinsey, "The state of AI in 2025: Agents, innovation, and transformation" (Nov 2025). 39% of respondents attribute any EBIT impact to AI. "High performers" are nearly three times as likely to have fundamentally redesigned workflows. [search-summary] https://www.mckinsey.com.br/en/our-insights/the-state-of-ai
    - Limitations: the EBIT impact is self-reported by respondents. "High performers" are defined by that same self-report. The data are cross-sectional, so successful firms may simply redesign more (reverse causality). And McKinsey sells redesign work.
- **[EVIDENCE: peer-reviewed theory with calibration]** Brynjolfsson, Rock & Syverson, "The Productivity J-Curve: How Intangibles Complement General Purpose Technologies", AEJ:

Macroeconomics 13(1): 333–72 (2021). General-purpose technologies need large, mostly intangible complementary investments (process redesign, training, new business models) that national accounts miss. So measured productivity is understated early and overstated later. Adjusting for hardware and software intangibles puts US TFP 15.9% above official figures by end-2017. AI-specific effects were "small but growing" at the time. [search-summary] https://www.aeaweb.org/doi/10.1257/mac.20180386; open working paper https://www.nber.org/papers/w25148

    - This is the strongest academic support for "the transformation is the hard part". But it is a macro argument about investment lags, not evidence that any particular change method works.

- **[EVIDENCE (weak: vendor self-study, n=132 surveyed + 53 interviews, August 2025)]** Anthropic surveyed its own engineers and researchers. They self-report using Claude in about 59% of their work, with about a 50% productivity gain, up from 28% and 20% a year earlier. The gain shows up as "considerably more output volume" rather than much less time per task. Staff also reported worry about skill atrophy and fewer mentoring interactions. Anthropic is an AI vendor, and this population is the most AI-fluent there is. (Verified: curl+grep) https://www.anthropic.com/research/how-ai-is-transforming-work-at-anthropic (2 Dec 2025)
    - Relevance: even in an AI-native firm, the "new way of working" changes how skills are learnt and passed on (who juniors ask, what gets practised). That is an education burden this track should name.

4. Generational, gender and country friction

- **[EVIDENCE]** Age. In Pew (Oct 2024), workers aged 18–29 were the most likely to use chatbots at least a few times a month. Younger and higher-income workers were more likely to feel hopeful or excited. [search-summary] https://www.pewresearch.org/internet/2025/02/25/u-s-workers-are-more-worried-than-hopeful-about-future-ai-use-in-the-workplace/
- **[EVIDENCE (weak: vendor survey)]** The Work Trend Index 2024 says bring-your-own-AI "cuts across all generations", not just Gen Z. (Verified: curl+grep) https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index/ai-at-work-is-here-now-comes-the-hard-part
- **Gap.** This session did not reach a source showing younger workers as more anxious. The brief's "more adoption but more anxiety" pattern is unverified here.
- **[EVIDENCE]** Gender. Otis, Cranney, Delecourt & Koning, "Global Evidence on Gender Gaps and Generative AI" (HBS/OSF working paper, Oct 2024, later revised). A meta-analysis of 16–18 studies covering more than 140,000 people finds women about 20% less likely than men to use generative AI. The gap appears in nearly all regions, sectors and occupations, and it persists in settings where access was equalised. The authors suggest ethical concerns and fear of being judged for relying on AI as possible drivers. [search-summary] https://www.hks.harvard.edu/centers/cid/publications/global-evidence-gender-gaps-and-generative-ai; https://www.library.hbs.edu/working-knowledge/women-are-avoiding-using-artificial-intelligence-can-that-hurt-their-careers
- **[EVIDENCE]** Humlum & Vestergaard (PNAS 2025) also find women less likely to have used ChatGPT within the same occupation. Women more often cite training needs, while men more often cite employer restrictions and data confidentiality. [search-summary] https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:nas:journl:v:122:y:2025:p:e2414972121
- **[EVIDENCE (vendor platform data, one model, consumer product)]** Country. Anthropic Economic Index (15 Sep 2025), based on 1 million Claude.ai conversations, uses an AI Usage Index (usage share ÷ working-age population share). Israel scores 7, Singapore 4.57, and India 0.27. Usage "strongly correlates with income". Low-usage countries are more likely to

delegate whole tasks (automation), while high-usage countries show more iteration (augmentation). This reflects one vendor's users only. (Verified: curl+grep) https://www.anthropic.com/research/anthropic-economic-index-september-2025-report

5. Middle management: blocker or lever?

- **[EVIDENCE (weak: polling firm, cross-sectional)]** Gallup, State of the Global Workplace 2026 (published around April 2026, covering 2025). Global manager engagement fell from 27% (2024) to 22% (2025), and from 31% in 2022. Gallup reports manager-led support as one of the two top drivers of frequent AI use, and says managers who champion AI raise employees' perception of AI impact "8.7-fold". I have not seen the primary text for this figure, so the exact wording and the comparison group are unverified. [search-summary] https://www.unleash.ai/strategy-and-leadership/analysis/gallups-state-of-the-global-workplace-2026-report-three-key-decisions-for-hr-leaders; earlier wave: https://www.hrdive.com/news/engagement-among-managers-is-slipping-affecting-ai-use-gallup/817069/
- **[EVIDENCE (weak: polling firm, cross-sectional)] Gallup primary figures (gap-fill pass).** Gallup's late-2025 workforce data:
    - In the private sector, at organisations that have adopted AI, 80% of employees are frequent users (a few times a week or more) where managers actively support AI, against 44% where support is low.
    - In the public sector the figures are 65% vs 37%.
    - Only about 28% of employees strongly agreed that their manager actively supports their use of AI.
    - Overall, 26% of workers used AI a few times a week or more and 12% daily (fall 2025).

  Gallup's AI indicator page, updated for May 2026, gives a smaller effect. 36% of employees in AI-integrating organisations strongly agree their manager supports the team's AI use, and those employees are 1.7 times as likely to be frequent users.

  Sources: https://www.gallup.com/workplace/699689/ai-use-at-work-rises.aspx ; https://gallup.com/workplace/702983/adoption-rapidly-growing-public-sector.aspx ; https://www.gallup.com/699797/indicator-artificial-intelligence.aspx (search extracts)

    - Note. Gallup's own figures put the manager effect at about 1.7 to 2 times on frequent use. That is far below the "8.7-fold" reported secondhand above, which concerns perceived impact, not use, and remains unverified. The share of employees with strong manager support (28% to 36%) is close to BCG's "about a quarter". All of these are cross-sectional associations.
- **[EVIDENCE (weak: consultancy survey)]** BCG AI at Work 2025 (n=10,635 employees, 11 countries; frontline staff, managers and leaders surveyed separately). Secondary reprints describe the "about 25%" support figure differently: as leaders giving enough guidance, or as C-suite support. The exact item wording is unknown (search extract, https://www.bigdatawire.com/this-just-in/bcg-report-companies-must-go-beyond-ai-adoption-to-realize-its-full-potential). Frontline regular use is 51%, stalled versus about 52% a year earlier. Only about a quarter of frontline staff say they get enough support from leaders. Positive sentiment toward generative AI rises from 15% to 55% with strong leadership support. Note that "frontline" in BCG's survey means frontline white-collar employees. [search-summary] https://www.bcg.com/press/26june2025-beyond-ai-adoption-full-potential; https://idm.net.au/node/15229

- **[EVIDENCE (weak: vendor survey, 31,000, Feb–Mar 2025)]** Work Trend Index 2025 (23 Apr 2025). "Last year, employees led the AI wave. This year, it's flipped." 67% of leaders are familiar with agents versus 40% of employees, and 79% of leaders versus 67% of employees think AI will accelerate their careers. (Verified: curl+grep) https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index/2025-the-year-the-frontier-firm-is-born

- **[OPINION / company statements]** De-layering. Microsoft's 2025 cuts were reported to target middle managers, with spans of control widening (per Business Insider; Microsoft gave no official statement at the time). Amazon talks about a "builder ratio", and Jassy's memo backed fewer layers. Google's Pichai told staff it had cut VP and manager roles by 10%. Zuckerberg described "defragmenting" Meta to reduce information latency. [search-summary] https://www.peoplematters.in/news/performance-management/microsoft-wants-leaner-teams-middle-management-layoffs-coming-in-may-45121; https://www.businessinsider.nl/companies-are-culling-managers-mark-zuckerberg-explained-his-mathematical-approach-to-it-nearly-2-years-ago/

- **Gap.** This session found no peer-reviewed or systematic study of the effects of the 2023–2025 big-tech de-layering. The evidence is executive statements and journalism, including a few employee anecdotes about more meetings and wider spans.

- **What has been measured (gap-fill pass, search extracts).** The scale of the flattening is measured. Its effects are not.

    - **[EVIDENCE (weak: polling firm)]** Gallup: the average manager's span of control rose from 10.9 direct reports in 2024 to 12.1 in 2025, up nearly 50% since 2013. Manager engagement is down 9 points since 2022. Via Fast Company https://www.fastcompany.com/91601567/the-great-flattening-rolls-on-as-uber-lays-off-middle-managers (search extract, secondary)
    - **[EVIDENCE (weak: job-postings data)]** Revelio Labs: middle-management job postings fell about 42% from their April 2022 peak to October 2025, while postings for other roles recovered. Via https://pipedot.org/6SNX5 and https://www.pulse.bot/ai/news/middle-managers-are-on-the-chopping-block-thanks-to-ai-in-the-workplace-heres-how-to-save-your-job-1155c975-f7cc-4d9c-97d9-83c8232340e8/ (search extracts, secondary). Indeed data reportedly show steady or rising manager postings in some sectors (construction, medical).
    - **[EVIDENCE (weak, year unclear)]** Live Data Technologies reportedly found middle managers made up 32% of layoffs in a recent year, against 20% in 2019. A Cornell ILR library summary puts them at over 31% of 2023 layoffs. https://catherwood.library.cornell.edu/wit/middle-managers-have-been-a-major-target-for-layoffs-in-the-past-year (search extract)
    - **[EVIDENCE (weak: consultancy survey)]** Korn Ferry 2025: about 4 in 10 respondents said their organisation had cut management layers. 40% of US employees said they felt a lack of direction because of reduced middle management. Korn Ferry warns that de-layering can lower productivity through lost support, higher turnover and weaker alignment. https://www.cfodive.com/news/cuts-middle-management-stressing-72-percent-senior-executives-korn-ferry-HR-WFH/745822/ (search extract)
    - **Still missing.** No causal or before-and-after study of de-layering's effect on AI adoption or productivity was found. A claim of a "15-20% productivity uplift" from removing middle managers appears only in a vendor blog, which cites unspecified McKinsey and BCG work. Do not cite it.

- **Synthesis.** The correlational data consistently say managers are the lever for frontline adoption. Firms are cutting manager layers at the same moment. Nobody has measured what that combination does to adoption. That contradiction is worth writing about.

6. Hiding AI use and shadow AI

- **[EVIDENCE (weak: vendor survey, n=31,000)]** Work Trend Index 2024. 78% of AI users bring their own AI tools to work (80% at small and medium companies). 52% are reluctant to admit using AI for their most important tasks. 53% worry it makes them look replaceable. (Verified: curl+grep) https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index/ai-at-work-is-here-now-comes-the-hard-part

- **[EVIDENCE (weak: vendor, crowdworker-recruited sample, n=1,250, AI-conducted interviews)]** Anthropic Interviewer (4 Dec 2025). 69% of professionals mentioned the social stigma that can come with using AI at work, and 70% of creatives mentioned managing peer judgement. Participants were recruited via crowdworker platforms, though crowdworking was not their main job. (Verified: curl+grep) https://www.anthropic.com/research/anthropic-interviewer

- **[EVIDENCE: academic-led survey with a Big Four sponsor] KPMG / University of Melbourne 2025 (gap-fill pass).** Gillespie, Lockey and colleagues (Melbourne Business School with KPMG), Trust, attitudes and use of artificial intelligence: A global study 2025. More than 48,000 people (48,340 per one outlet) in 47 countries, surveyed November 2024 to January 2025.

    - 57% of employees say they hide their use of AI and present AI-generated work as their own.
    - Almost half admit using AI in ways that contravene company policy, including uploading sensitive company information into free public tools.
    - Only 47% say they have received AI training, and 40% say their workplace has a policy or guidance on generative AI.

  https://mbs.edu/news/global-study-reveals-trust-of-ai-remains-a-critical-challenge ; https://fbe.unimelb.edu.au/newsroom/media-release-global-study-reveals-trust-of-ai-remains-a-critical-challenge-reflecting-tension-between-benefits-and-risks (search extracts). Sampling method (online panels per country) not confirmed this session.

    - Relevance. A non-vendor, 47-country source agrees with Microsoft's 52% "reluctant to admit". Hidden use is a majority behaviour, not a niche one. This is the best evidence for the thesis's "no shared context" point: most AI use at work is invisible to the organisation.

- **[EVIDENCE (weak: consultancy survey)]** BCG 2025: more than half of employees say they would use AI tools even if not authorised. [search-summary] https://www.bcg.com/press/26june2025-beyond-ai-adoption-full-potential

- **Implication for the thesis.** Hidden use means the "legacy" end of the spectrum is less legacy than it looks. AI is already in the workflow, but untracked and outside any shared context. That supports the "shared context" part of the thesis and undercuts the "people resist" part.

7. Resistance as rational: job fear and workload

- **[EVIDENCE]** Pew (Oct 2024, n=5,273). 52% of workers are worried about AI's future use in the workplace, 36% hopeful, 33% overwhelmed and 29% excited. [search-summary] https://www.pewresearch.org/internet/2025/02/25/u-s-workers-are-more-worried-than-hopeful-about-future-ai-use-in-the-workplace/
- **[EVIDENCE (weak: vendor survey)]** Work Trend Index 2024: 45% of professionals worry AI will replace their job. (Verified: curl+grep). Work Trend Index 2025: 43% "globally" fear AI will take their jobs, versus 21% of "Frontier Firm" leaders. (Verified: curl+grep) https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index/2025-the-year-the-frontier-firm-is-born
- **[EVIDENCE (weak: vendor survey; see the trace below)]** Upwork Research Institute (with Workplace Intelligence; fieldwork by Walr, 16 Apr–5 May 2024; US, UK, Australia, Canada; published 23 Jul 2024). 77% of employees who use AI say it has added to their workload. 47% don't know how to achieve the productivity gains their employers expect. [search-summary] https://investors.upwork.com/news-releases/news-release-details/upwork-study-finds-employee-workloads-rising-despite-increased-c
- **[EVIDENCE]** Humlum & Vestergaard (NBER w33777) find that chatbots create new job tasks, especially where employers encourage use, which partly offsets time saved. [search-summary] https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:nbr:nberwo:33777. Anthropic's internal study likewise finds gains taken as more output, not less time (verified). Together these give mechanism-level support to the claim that "AI intensifies work", independent of Upwork.

Viral statistics traced

Statistic	Where cited from	Actual origin	How solid
"70% of change programmes fail"	Kotter, McKinsey, Bain, consultancies, countless decks	Hammer & Champy 1993, given as an "unscientific estimate" (50–70%) about reengineering; Beer & Nohria (HBR 2000). Hughes (2011) found all five common citations lack valid empirical support.	**Weak.** No credible base rate. Do not cite as fact. Contested by Burnes & Jackson (2011), whose evidence I did not check.
"77% of employees say AI has added to their workload" (Upwork, 2024)	HR press, LinkedIn posts, often given as "77% of workers"	Upwork press release, 23 Jul 2024. Total n=2,500, but 1,250 of those are C-suite executives. The 77% applies only to AI-using employees among 625 full-time employees and 625 freelancers in four English-speaking countries. Online panel (Walr). Upwork sells freelance labour as a remedy.	**Weak.** A vendor survey with a small base and unclear question wording. Directionally consistent with Humlum & Vestergaard's "new tasks" finding. Cite as "an Upwork survey of about 1,250 workers" if at all.
"78% of AI users bring their own AI to work"	Microsoft/ LinkedIn WTI 2024, widely quoted as "shadow AI"	WTI 2024: 31,000 knowledge workers, 31 markets, online, Edelman. (Verified)	**Moderate for direction, weak for level.** A large sample, but online knowledge workers only, run by a vendor with an interest in sanctioned (Copilot) adoption.
"Workflow redesign is the #1 driver of EBIT impact" (McKinsey)	Consultancy content, LinkedIn	McKinsey State of AI survey, March 2025. Association between 25 attributes and self-reported EBIT impact.	**Weak.** A self-reported outcome, cross-sectional, with commercial interest. It is a correlation, not a driver.
"Managers who champion AI boost perceived	HR press, 2026	Gallup, State of the Global Workplace 2026 (secondary reports)	**Unverified.** Could not reach Gallup. The comparison is likely across groups of respondents, so not causal. Gallup's own figures on use show an effect of 1.7 to 2 times

Statistic	Where cited from	Actual origin	How solid
AI impact 8.7-fold" (Gallup)			(80% vs 44%; 1.7x in May 2026), so cite those instead.
"AI mindset training made staff twice as likely to do top-quality work" (Gap Inc. / Microsoft, 2026)	Gap press release, retail-tech press	arXiv 2604.08678, RCT of 388 Gap employees, Microsoft authors, no IRB	**Weak as a general claim.** A top-tail result. The intent-to-treat average showed no significant difference because 68% of all participants hit the score ceiling.
"57% of employees hide their AI use" (KPMG/ Melbourne 2025)	HR and tech press	Gillespie, Lockey et al., 48,000+ respondents, 47 countries, Nov 2024 to Jan 2025	**Moderate.** Large multi-country academic-led survey. The item also covers presenting AI work as one's own. Online self-report. Sampling not checked this session.

Strongest counter-evidence

Against the thesis ("people resist a whole new way of working"):

- Bottom-up adoption is fast and widespread. Bick et al. find adoption faster than PCs or the internet at a similar stage, and 78% of AI users bring their own tools. Workers in Denmark cite employer restrictions and lack of training, not unwillingness. The organisation, through its policy, permission, procurement and fear of data leakage, is often the brake. The employees are not.
- Hidden use (52% reluctant to admit; 69% mention stigma) means apparent "resistance" may partly be invisible adoption.

Against "the business isn't ready, so AI fails":

- In Denmark, broad adoption with employer encouragement still produced average time savings of only about 3% and no earnings or hours effects (Humlum & Vestergaard). Even when adoption and encouragement are present, gains for typical workers are small. Readiness may not be the binding constraint. The tool's marginal value in many ordinary jobs may be.
- Work hours spent with generative AI are only about 5.7% of all US hours (Bick et al., Aug 2025). The upside from "fixing readiness" is bounded by how little work currently touches AI.

Against the mainstream reading of change management:

- The "70% fail" base rate is unsupported. "Transformation is hard" may be true, but nobody has measured how hard in a way that supports the folklore.
- The strongest evidence that redesign matters (the J-curve) predicts delayed gains, not failure. Firms reporting "no ROI yet" may be early on the curve rather than failing.

Against "training fixes it" (gap-fill pass):

- In the one randomised training trial found (Gap/Microsoft, n=388), mindset training made no detectable difference to average output quality. In the Kenya RCT, AI help widened the gap between strong and weak operators. The randomised evidence that training or access lifts the typical worker is thin.

Against "managers are the lever":

- The evidence (Gallup, BCG) is cross-sectional. Teams with supportive managers may differ in many ways, such as role type and resources. No causal estimate was found.

Open questions

1. Is there an independent, peer-reviewed RCT of AI training (not access) on business outcomes? The gap-fill pass found one vendor-authored preprint (Gap/Microsoft, null on average), plus access experiments showing large firm effects (Copilot, 21% to 75% weekly use). What firm-level factor explains that spread?
2. KPMG/Melbourne 2025: answered in part (57% hide use; almost half contravene policy). Still to check: the country breakdown, the sampling method, and whether hiding is higher where policy is restrictive.
3. What do Gallup's primary releases say about the "8.7-fold" manager effect, its comparison group and its wording?
4. Has anyone measured adoption or productivity after de-layering? Academic span-of-control literature, and Amazon or Meta disclosures.
5. Is there credible evidence that younger workers are more anxious about AI at work? Pew suggests the opposite.
6. What does Gartner's manager or "change fatigue" research actually measure? Not reached.
7. Does the gender gap close in firms with mandated or sanctioned tools, or only in experiments? Otis et al. say no even with equal access, but firm-level evidence is thin.

What's genuinely uncertain

- **Causality of every "lever".** Manager support, training and workflow redesign all correlate with better outcomes in cross-sectional surveys. None has a clean causal estimate in what I found.
- **Whether small measured gains reflect a J-curve lag or a ceiling.** The Danish 3% could rise as complementary investment accumulates, or it could be the realistic level for many occupations.
- **Level of hidden use.** BYOAI estimates come from vendor surveys of online knowledge workers. True prevalence across all workers, including frontline and SMB, is unknown.
- **Effects of de-layering on adoption.** There is no data. Opinion runs in both directions.
- **Secondary-only numbers.** All figures marked [search-summary] need re-checking against the primary page. Because of the access limits, this applies to BCG, Gallup, Pew, McKinsey, Humlum & Vestergaard, Otis et al., Bick et al. and Upwork.

Numbers for the facts file

Figure	What it measures	Source	URL	Date	Reliability note
0 valid studies	Empirical support for "70% of change initiatives fail" found by Hughes across 5 cited sources	Hughes, J. Change Mgmt 11(4)	https://research.brighton.ac.uk/en/publications/do-70-per-cent-of-all-organizational-change-initiatives-really-fa/	2011	Peer-reviewed; contested by Burnes & Jackson 2011. [search-summary]

Figure	What it measures	Source	URL	Date	Reliability note
78 %	AI users bringing their own AI tools to work (80% at SMBs)	Microsoft/ LinkedIn WTI 2024, n=31,000	https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index/ai-at-work-is-here-now-comes-the-hard-part	8 May 2024	Vendor survey, online knowledge workers. Verified curl+grep.
52 %	AI users reluctant to admit using it for their most important tasks	WTI 2024	same	8 May 2024	Vendor survey. Verified.
53 %	AI users worried that using it on important tasks makes them look replaceable	WTI 2024	same	8 May 2024	Vendor survey. Verified.
39 %	AI users who have received AI training from their company	WTI 2024	same	8 May 2024	Vendor survey. Verified.
67 % vs 40 %	Leaders vs employees familiar with AI agents	WTI 2025, n=31,000	https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index/2025-the-year-the-frontier-firm-is-born	23 Apr 2025	Vendor survey. Verified.
43 %	Workers globally who fear AI will take their jobs	WTI 2025	same	23 Apr 2025	Vendor survey. Verified.
77 %	AI-using employees saying AI added to their workload	Upwork Research Institute	https://investors.upwork.com/news-releases/news-release-details/upwork-study-finds-employee-workloads-rising-despite-increased-c	23 Jul 2024	Vendor; base is about 1,250 non-executives in 4 countries. [search-summary]
52 % / 36 %	US workers worried / hopeful about AI at work	Pew, n=5,273, Oct 2024	https://www.pewresearch.org/internet/2025/02/25/u-s-workers-are-more-worried-than-hopeful-about-future-ai-use-in-the-workplace/	25 Feb 2025	Probability panel; strong. [search-summary]
50 % / 28 %	US employees using AI at work at all / frequently	Gallup, n=23,717, Feb 2026	https://www.tomshardware.com/tech-industry/artificial-intelligence/half-of-all-us-employees-now-use-artificial-intelligence-at-work-crossing-landmark-threshold-for-first-time-gallup-data-shows-daily-and-weekly-usage-hitting-all-time-high-of-28-percent-in-q1-2026-with-65-percent-feeling-positive-about-its-impact-on-productivity	Q1 2026	Strong panel; secondary report. [search-summary]
54.6%	US adults 18–64 who have used generative AI	Bick, Blandin & Deming, St Louis Fed	https://www.stlouisfed.org/on-the-economy/2025/nov/state-generative-ai-adoption-2025	13 Nov 2025	Nationally representative. [search-summary]
4.1 % to 5.7 %	Share of all US work hours spent using generative AI, Nov 2024 to Aug 2025	same	same	13 Nov 2025	[search-summary]
about 3%	Average time saved by chatbot users in Denmark; earnings and hours effects about 0	Humlum & Vestergaard, NBER w33777	https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:nbr:nberwo:33777	2025	Survey linked to registers; strong. [search-summary]
about	How much less likely women are	Otis, Cranney,	https://www.hks.harvard.edu/centers/cid/publications/global-evidence-gender-gaps-and-generative-ai	Oct 2024 (rev.)	Meta-analysis of 16–18 studies, more

Figure	What it measures	Source	URL	Date	Reliability note
20 %	than men to use generative AI	Delecourt & Koning			than 140,000 people. [search-summary]
51 %	Frontline (white-collar) employees who are regular AI users; stalled	BCG AI at Work 2025	https://www.bcg.com/press/26june2025-beyond-ai-adoption-full-potential	26 Jun 2025	Consultancy survey. [search-summary]
15 % to 55 %	Positive sentiment toward generative AI, without vs with strong leadership support	BCG AI at Work 2025	same	26 Jun 2025	Cross-sectional. [search-summary]
27 % to 22 %	Global manager engagement, 2024 to 2025	Gallup State of the Global Workplace 2026	https://www.unleash.ai/strategy-and-leadership/analysis/gallups-state-of-the-global-workplace-2026-report-three-key-decisions-for-hr-leaders	Apr 2026	Secondary. [search-summary]
21 %	Generative AI users who have fundamentally redesigned at least some workflows	McKinsey State of AI	https://artificialintellitools.blogspot.com/2025/04/briefing-document-state-of-ai-how.html	Mar 2025	Consultancy; secondary blog. [search-summary]
15.9%	US TFP level above official figures by end-2017 after adjusting for IT intangibles	Brynjolfsson, Rock & Syverson, AEJ Macro	https://www.aeaweb.org/doi/10.1257/mac.20180386	2021	Peer-reviewed. [search-summary]
69 %	Professionals interviewed who mentioned social stigma of AI use at work	Anthropic Interviewer, n=1,250	https://www.anthropic.com/research/anthropic-interviewer	4 Dec 2025	Vendor; crowdworker-recruited sample. Verified.
57 %	Employees who hide AI use and present AI output as their own	KPMG / Univ. of Melbourne 2025, n≈48,000, 47 countries	https://mbs.edu/news/global-study-reveals-trust-of-ai-remains-a-critical-challenge	Apr 2025 (fieldwork Nov 2024 to Jan 2025)	Academic-led, Big Four sponsor. Search extract
~50%	Employees using AI in ways that contravene company policy	same	same	2025	"Almost half". Search extract
47 % / 40 %	Employees with AI training / with a workplace genAI policy	same	same	2025	Search extract
80 % vs 44 %	Frequent AI use where managers actively support vs low support (private sector, AI-adopting orgs)	Gallup	https://www.gallup.com/workplace/699689/ai-use-at-work-rises.aspx	late 2025	Cross-sectional. Search extract
1.7 x / 36 %	Frequent-use multiplier with strong manager support / share with strong support	Gallup AI indicator	https://www.gallup.com/699797/indicator-artificial-intelligence.aspx	May 2026	Search extract

Figure	What it measures	Source	URL	Date	Reliability note
21 % to 75 %	Weekly Copilot use among treated workers, range across 66 firms	Dillon et al., NBER w33795, n=7,137	https://www.nber.org/system/files/working_papers/w33795/w33795.pdf	2025	Randomised access; firm effects. Microsoft co-authors
68 %	Gap RCT participants at maximum quality score (all arms), so no ITT difference was detectable	arXiv 2604.08678, n=388	https://arxiv.org/abs/2604.08678	Apr 2026	Preprint, Microsoft authors, no IRB
10.9 to 12.1	Average direct reports per manager, 2024 to 2025	Gallup via Fast Company	https://www.fastcompany.com/91601567/the-great-flattening-rolls-on-as-uber-lays-off-middle-managers	2025-26	Secondary
-42 %	Middle-manager job postings, Apr 2022 peak to Oct 2025	Revelio Labs via secondary	https://pipedot.org/6SNX5	late 2025	Postings, not employment. Secondary
40 %	US employees feeling lack of direction due to fewer middle managers	Korn Ferry 2025	https://www.cfodive.com/news/cuts-middle-management-stressing-72-percent-senior-executives-korn-ferry-HR-WFH/745822/	2025	Consultancy survey
7 / 0.27	Claude usage per working-age capita relative to expected (Israel / India)	Anthropic Economic Index	https://www.anthropic.com/research/anthropic-economic-index-september-2025-report	15 Sep 2025	One vendor's consumer users. Verified.

Verbatim quotes

- "Without guidance or clearance from the top, employees are taking things into their own hands and keeping AI use under wraps: 78% of AI users are bringing their own AI tools to work (BYOAI)" (Microsoft and LinkedIn, Work Trend Index 2024, 8 May 2024) https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index/ai-at-work-is-here-now-comes-the-hard-part. Context: framing of shadow AI. Verified: curl+grep
- "52% of people who use AI at work are reluctant to admit to using it for their most important tasks." (Microsoft and LinkedIn, Work Trend Index 2024, 8 May 2024) https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index/ai-at-work-is-here-now-comes-the-hard-part. Context: hidden use. Verified: curl+grep
- "Only 39% of people globally who use AI at work have gotten AI training from their company." (Microsoft and LinkedIn, Work Trend Index 2024, 8 May 2024) https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index/ai-at-work-is-here-now-comes-the-hard-part. Context: training deficit. Verified: curl+grep
- "Last year, employees led the AI wave. This year, it's flipped." (Microsoft, Work Trend Index 2025, 23 Apr 2025) https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index/2025-the-year-the-frontier-firm-is-born. Context: leaders now ahead of employees on agent familiarity. Verified: curl+grep
- "69% of professionals mentioned the social stigma that can come with using AI tools at work" (Anthropic, "Introducing Anthropic Interviewer", 4 Dec 2025) https://www.anthropic.com/research/anthropic-interviewer. Context: 1,250 AI-conducted interviews; vendor source. Verified: curl+grep

- "A colleague recently said they hate AI and I just said nothing. I don't tell anyone my process because I know how a lot of people feel about AI." (Fact-checker interviewed by Anthropic Interviewer, 4 Dec 2025) https://www.anthropic.com/research/anthropic-interviewer. Context: hidden AI use because of peer stigma. Verified: curl+grep (the page uses a curly apostrophe)
- "When producing output is so easy and fast, it gets harder and harder to actually take the time to learn something." (Anthropic employee, quoted in "How AI is transforming work at Anthropic", 2 Dec 2025) https://www.anthropic.com/research/how-ai-is-transforming-work-at-anthropic. Context: skill-atrophy concern in an AI-native firm. Verified: curl+grep
- "More junior people don't come to me with questions as often." (Anthropic employee, same source, 2 Dec 2025) https://www.anthropic.com/research/how-ai-is-transforming-work-at-anthropic. Context: mentoring and learning loss. Verified: curl+grep

(No quotes from Hughes, Hammer & Champy, Gallup, BCG, Pew or McKinsey, because their pages could not be fetched. Those are paraphrased above.)

Sources worth reading in full

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4. Brynjolfsson, Rock & Syverson, "The Productivity J-Curve" (2021). The theory behind "the transformation is the hard part", and why early ROI looks bad. https://www.nber.org/papers/w25148
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9. Anthropic, "How AI is transforming work at Anthropic" (Dec 2025). Rare qualitative detail on learning and mentoring loss inside an AI-native firm; vendor self-study. https://www.anthropic.com/research/how-ai-is-transforming-work-at-anthropic
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